

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE BAHAMAS

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the Bahamas' distinctive lever — uniting a nation around its shared heritage (natural, historical, and ancestral), defending the coast as a commons, and winning lasting protection in law — and it names the tools you'll meet (the EIA and environmental authorisation, heritage and national-park designation, protective legislation, the courts) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Around the turn of the millennium, developers proposed to bulldoze the coast at **Clifton** — a strip of scrub forest, wetlands, reef, and cliffs on the western tip of New Providence, near Nassau — for a gated complex of some six hundred homes and an eighteen-hole golf course. But Clifton was not empty land. It held the only place in the Bahamas where the memory of all three of the islands' peoples survives on a single site: the village of the **Lucayans**, the first Bahamians, who met Columbus and were gone within a generation; the ruins of an eighteenth-century **plantation**; and the quarters of the **enslaved Africans** who worked it. Bahamians from every walk of life rose to defend it. Environmentalists, historians, artists, and ordinary citizens joined a grassroots **Fight to Save Clifton** — and they won: in 2004 an **act of Parliament** set the land aside as the **Clifton Heritage National Park**, and the bulldozers never came. A coast of ancestors was saved from becoming a private enclave, and made permanent by law.

The Fight to Save Clifton drew on tools available to communities across the Bahamas. A major project needs an **EIA and environmental authorisation**. **Heritage and national-park designation**, backed by **protective legislation**, can lock a place away permanently — as an act of Parliament did for Clifton. The **courts** are open; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And the most powerful lever here was the **coast as a commons** — the claim that a shore belongs to the nation, not a private enclave — carried by an appeal to the country's shared inheritance, natural, historical, and ancestral, that united people who agreed on little else. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The Bahamas lives on **tourism and coastal development**, so the pressure to build resorts, marinas, and gated enclaves on every beautiful shore is **structural and relentless**, and Clifton was one battle in a long war — later fights, on other coasts and cays, have been harder and some have been **lost or ground down**. The Clifton win required not just protest but the **political will** to set the land aside, which had to be won. And it was achieved in a **functioning democracy** with a free press and open civic space. So draw courage from the victory without mistaking it for a guarantee: find the shared heritage, make the coast the nation's own, and secure it in law — and know that not every fine coast can be saved.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Bahamian coastal project needs its **EIA and authorisation**; it can be challenged in the **courts**; and, above all, a place of **shared heritage** can be turned into a national cause and locked in by **protective legislation**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the shared heritage, secured in law, is the one that made Clifton permanent. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the place holds shared heritage — natural, historical, or ancestral — that is your sharpest, most unifying lever** — it can make one coast the whole nation's cause.
- **If the coast is being privatized, defending it as a commons is a powerful claim** — a public shore belongs to the nation.
- **If the EIA or authorisation is defective, the process and the courts are real grounds.**
- **If tourism development is relentless, expect a long war with mixed results** — aim for a project stopped, a coast protected, and — the durable win — lasting protection in law, and keep fighting the next battle.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **find the shared heritage, make the coast the nation's own, and secure it in law** — the Clifton template — and **build the broadest, most diverse coalition**, because a place of ancestors can unite people who agree on little else. That's how Clifton was saved.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

A major project needs an **EIA and environmental authorisation** from the environment authority, and planning and Crown-land approvals from the government. **Heritage and national-park designation**, and **protective legislation**, can permanently set land aside. The **courts** review the legality of decisions. And in a small democracy, the **government and Parliament** are sensitive to the nation's attention and to a unifying heritage cause. Know which decision — or which protective law — you can reach, and aim there.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and authorisation. The project is assessed and authorised. *Your opening:* take part, put your objections on the record, and attack the assessment's flaws.

The heritage and the coast. *Your opening — the distinctive one:* establish the site's **shared heritage** and its status as a **public coast**, and make it the nation's cause.

The protective law. *Your opening — the durable one:* press for **heritage/national-park designation and protective legislation** to lock the place in permanently, as Clifton was.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — the developer, and any foreign capital, whose reputation you can reach. **What heritage and coast it threatens** — because shared heritage and a public shore are your unifying levers. **What it still needs** — the authorisation, the Crown-land grant, the political go-ahead: whatever's missing is the soft spot.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment authority** runs the EIA and authorisation. **Parliament** can pass protective legislation and set land aside. The **courts** review decisions. And the Bahamas'

environmental, heritage, and cultural organisations, historians, artists, and a free press are the forces that reach furthest — the diverse coalition that saved Clifton.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the place holds shared heritage, whether the coalition can unite the nation, and how relentless the development pressure is.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the EIA	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Establish and dramatise the shared heritage	30–55%	months	low	One coast becomes the nation's cause
Defend the coast as a commons	25–50%	months–yr	low	Privatization resisted; public claim
Court challenge (authorisation)	25–50%	months–yr	mod	Authorisation quashed; process ordered
Broad, diverse coalition + national attention	30–55%	months–yr	low	Political will to protect built
Win protective legislation / designation	30–55%	months–yr	mod	Lasting legal protection (Clifton)
Everything together (shared heritage, nation united, protective law)	40–65%	1–3 yr	mod	Stopped, protected, secured in law
Everything together (relentless tourism pressure)	20–45%	1–3 yr	mod	Some won, some lost; a long war

The levers that move the needle most are the **shared heritage** that unites the nation and the **protective legislation** that locks a place in, backed by the diverse coalition, the commons claim, and the courts. Clifton shows the ceiling (a coast of ancestors saved and made a national park by law) and the honest floor (one battle in a long war, later fights lost). So aim for a project stopped, a coast protected, and lasting protection in law — and keep fighting the next battle.

On cost: organising, documenting the heritage, and campaigning are cheap; the strength is a diverse coalition and a unifying cause, not money. The great strength is that a place of shared heritage can unite a nation that agrees on little else — and the durable win is protective legislation, so aim to lock the place in by law.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this heritage, this public coast, this defective authorisation — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the developer, and any foreign capital.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over the **coast, reef, mangrove, wetlands** — and the **natural, historical, and ancestral heritage** of the site. **Shared heritage and a public coast are your sharpest, most unifying levers** — Clifton held the memory of all three of the nation's peoples.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the EIA in process? Has the authorisation issued (opening the courts)? Is there a window to press for protective legislation? These openings are time-bound.

4. What does it still need that it lacks? The authorisation, the Crown-land grant, the political go-ahead. The missing piece is the soft spot.

5. Can you unite a diverse nation? Environmentalists, historians, artists, cultural and church groups, ordinary citizens. Clifton's power was a coalition that agreed on little else but this.

What this looks like in real life. A gated resort or marina threatens a public coast that holds natural and ancestral heritage. The five questions yield: a developer and its capital; a heritage coast and a public shore at stake (the unifying levers); an EIA or authorisation in process; a project needing the go-ahead; and a diverse nation to unite. That's the Clifton pattern — establish the shared heritage, make the coast the nation's own, and press for protective law.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — and at Clifton the decisive proof was the heritage. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the heritage. Establish and document the site's **shared heritage** — the natural (reef, mangrove, wetlands, wildlife), the historical (ruins, sites), and the ancestral (Indigenous, colonial, enslaved-African). At Clifton, archaeologists showed what the ground held; get the science and the history that make the case irrefutable.

Layer two: the paper trail and the harm. Get the EIA, the authorisation, the Crown-land and planning records, and the developer's plans, and document the harm — the privatization of the coast, the destruction of the heritage and the reef. Read the EIA for flaws.

Layer three: the map of heritage and harm. Lay the project over the heritage sites, the reef and mangrove, and the public shore, so the loss — natural, historical, and ancestral — is undeniable. Walking into the authority, the courts, Parliament, or the nation with the heritage documented and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The heritage evidence** — natural, historical (archaeology), and ancestral — the irrefutable core.
- **The EIA, the authorisation, the Crown-land and planning records, the developer's plans** — from the environment authority and the government.
- **Ownership and financing** — the developer and any foreign capital.
- **The heritage-and-harm map** — the heritage sites, the reef and mangrove, and the public shore, laid over the project.
- **Named testimony** — of those who value the coast and its heritage.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a diverse nation united around its heritage gives you power — the Clifton model. Build in four moves.

Build the broadest, most diverse coalition. Clifton's strength was breadth beyond the usual — environmentalists, historians, artists, and ordinary citizens, people who agreed on little else. Build that broad, diverse front, because a place of shared heritage can unite them.

Lead with the ancestral heritage. The deepest, most unifying claim at Clifton was the ancestors — the first Bahamians, and above all the enslaved Africans remembered on that ground. Reach past the environmental argument to that shared inheritance; it is what makes one coast the whole nation's cause.

Defend the coast as a commons. Frame the fight as protecting a **public shore** from becoming a private enclave — a claim that resonates in a nation whose coasts are its birthright.

Build to last, and aim for protective law. Bahamian fights run against a relentless tide. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the toll — and, above all, aim for the durable win: **heritage/national-park designation and protective legislation**, which locks the place in as Clifton was.

STEP 4: LEGAL & LEGISLATIVE LEVERS

The Bahamas' sharpest levers are the shared heritage, the protective law, and the courts.

Establish the Shared Heritage — the Unifying Lever

The Clifton foundation: establish and dramatise the site's **shared heritage** — natural, historical, and, most powerfully, **ancestral** — turning one coast into the nation's cause. A place where a nation's ancestors are remembered unites people who agree on little else, and gives the campaign a moral force no developer can match.

The Coast as a Commons and the EIA

Frame the coast as a **public commons** being privatized, take part in the **EIA**, attack a defective authorisation, and — where the process or the law is breached — challenge it in the **courts**. These build the record and the pressure.

Protective Legislation — the Durable Win

The Clifton victory was made permanent by an **act of Parliament** and **national-park designation**. Press for **protective legislation and heritage/national-park status** to lock the place in permanently — because in a tourism economy where the pressure never ends, a protection in law is the only durable win.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the shared heritage, the protective law, and the courts are powerful, but tourism development is relentless, Clifton was one battle in a long war, and the political will has to be won each time. So use the strong tools — the heritage, the commons claim, the EIA, the courts, and above all protective legislation — pair them with a diverse coalition and the nation's attention, and count a project stopped, a coast protected, and lasting protection in law as wins — then fight the next battle.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Heritage becomes a national cause. Not "we oppose the resort" but *"this would bulldoze the one place where the memory of all our peoples — Lucayan, colonial, and enslaved African — survives together."*

A coast becomes a commons. *"This public shore belongs to the nation — it cannot be sold to a private enclave."*

A defective authorisation becomes a challenge. *"The EIA understated the harm to our reef and heritage — the authorisation is unsound."*

A win becomes a law. *"Let us make this protection permanent, by an act of Parliament, as we did at Clifton."*

Match it to the venue: the heritage to the nation and Parliament; the commons to the public and the courts; the defective authorisation to the courts; the protection to Parliament as legislation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In the Bahamas, the nation's attention is a decisive lever — a small country can be united around its heritage, as Clifton united it. A free press and heritage and cultural organisations make the media front central.

Lead with the ancestors and the coast, not procedure. Not "the EIA was deficient" but "the one place where our ancestors — the first Bahamians and the enslaved Africans — are remembered, bulldozed for a private enclave." Use your strongest material: the heritage and archaeology, dated photographs, the map, and the voices of the nation.

Work several audiences at once. Local and national press unite the nation; cultural, historical, and diaspora networks amplify the ancestral heritage; the commons claim resonates widely. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And let the diverse coalition — environmental, historical, cultural — shape the story together, keeping the frame on the shared heritage.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the environment authority).

Subject: Request for the EIA and authorisation — [project].

"We, citizens of [place], request the EIA, the environmental authorisation, and the Crown-land and planning records for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the EIA.

Subject: Objection — [project].

"We, citizens of [place], object to [project]: [it privatizes a public coast; it destroys natural, historical, and ancestral heritage; the EIA understates the harm]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Establishing the heritage (to the authorities / public).

Subject: The shared heritage at [place].

"We record that [place] holds [natural / historical / ancestral] heritage: [specifics — the archaeology, the ancestors]. This coast belongs to the nation's memory and must be protected. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Pressing for protective legislation (to Parliament / ministers).

Subject: Protect [place] permanently, as at Clifton.

"We, citizens of [place], call on Parliament to set [place] aside as a [heritage/national park] by law, protecting its shared heritage and public coast permanently, as was done at Clifton. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Possible challenge — [project] authorisation.

"Our community faces [project] destroying [heritage/coast] on [a defective authorisation]. We've gathered [the EIA, the heritage evidence, photographs]. We ask your advice on challenging it. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the developer / foreign capital.

Subject: Heritage and reputational risk in [project].

"We are the community defending [place] from [project]. It bulldozes shared heritage and privatizes a public coast, and faces a united nation and legal challenge. As at Clifton, this carries real risk. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect [place] from [project].

"[Place] holds [our reef / our ancestors' memory]. Now [project] threatens it — a public coast to be sold as a private enclave. We can provide the heritage evidence, photographs, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the nation.

Subject: This coast is ours — here's how we save it.

"[Project] would bulldoze [our heritage coast]. At Clifton, a diverse nation united around its shared heritage, defended the coast as a commons, and made it a national park by law. If we unite the same way, we can save this place too. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. Establish the site's shared heritage — natural, historical, and above all ancestral (8C). That's your unifying lever.

2. **Frame the coast as a public commons, and object in the EIA (8B).**
3. **Request the documents (8A), and read the EIA for flaws.**
4. **Build the broadest, most diverse coalition and unite the nation (8H/8G).**
5. **Press for protective legislation and national-park designation (8D) — the durable win.**
6. **Get a lawyer for a defective authorisation (8E), and keep fighting the next battle.**

Even lean, those six find the shared heritage, make the coast the nation's own, and aim to secure it in law — the Clifton template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The Bahamas' tools are real, but the tourism tide tilts the field, and you must plan for it.

When development pressure is relentless. Clifton was one battle in a long war. Draw courage from it without expecting every coast to be saved, and pick the fights where the heritage and the commons claim give you a chance.

When the political will must be won. Protection took an act of Parliament, which had to be won. Build the national cause that makes the political will follow, and press for the protective law.

When later fights are lost. Some coasts have been lost. Keep the coalition alive, learn from each battle, and fight the next.

When the win must be made permanent. A stopped project can return. Lock the place in with protective legislation and national-park designation, as Clifton was.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

The Bahamas has real concerns about the closeness of developers and foreign capital to Crown-land and coastal decisions, so this matters.

How to spot it. Public coast and Crown land handed to developers on opaque terms; authorisations against the evidence; EIAs written for the proponent; benefits to the connected while the nation loses its coast and heritage.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Auditor General** examines public money. Anti-corruption and integrity bodies handle conduct. The **courts** can quash a tainted authorisation. And the Bahamas' **press, heritage, and civil-society organisations** have exposed captured deals.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the coast was handed over, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the Auditor General, the integrity bodies, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the heritage cause and the push for protective law.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The heritage evidence and documents build your case; the shared heritage aims it; a diverse nation united is the muscle; the EIA and the courts press

the case; the drive for protective legislation locks it in; the press unites the nation. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and fight the next battle.

Early on (weeks 1–8): establish and document the shared heritage; object in the EIA; request the records; build the broadest, most diverse coalition and unite the nation.

In the thick of it (months–year): make the coast a national cause; challenge a defective authorisation; press for protective legislation and national-park designation; open the media front.

The long haul (year+): carry the litigation and the legislative push; lock the place in by law; keep the coalition alive for the next battle; hold the line for a project stopped, a coast protected, and lasting protection in law.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in the Bahamas can be done — a diverse nation united around a coast of ancestors, saved it from a private enclave, and made it a national park by law. Hold both truths. The Bahamas' distinctive power is real: in a small tourism democracy, a broad coalition that unites the nation around its shared heritage — natural, historical, and above all ancestral — can defend a public coast from privatization and win lasting protection in law. And the constraints are real: a relentless tourism-development pressure, a mixed record of later fights won and lost, and a political will that must be won each time.

Here's the discipline that wins. Find the shared heritage — the reef and mangrove, the ruins, and above all the ancestors — and make one coast the whole nation's cause, reaching past the environmental argument to a shared inheritance that unites people who agree on little else. Defend the coast as a public commons being privatized. Take part in the EIA and challenge a defective authorisation in the courts. Build the broadest, most diverse coalition, and — the durable win — press for protective legislation and national-park designation that locks the place in permanently, as Clifton was locked in. Draw courage from the victory without mistaking it for a guarantee, and keep fighting the next battle, because the tide never stops. Count a project stopped, a coast protected, and lasting protection in law as wins. That's what the Fight to Save Clifton did — the shared heritage, the united nation, the commons, and the protective law together. So can you.